

Session 1: What Does “Gospel” Mean?

Key Takeaways

- Learning about the origin of the gospels and how they were put together helps us understand what Matthew is trying to tell us on Matthew’s own terms.
- The Greek word *euangelion* (“gospel,” “good news”), was used by others in the Roman world, like Caesar, to promote their own agenda. The good news about Jesus confronts these other gospels and offers a vision of God’s plan for the world.
- The gospels came into existence not as library archives but out of the life mission of actual communities of a persecuted religious minority.

Introduction to the Fourfold Gospel

Matthew, Mark, Luke, and John offer the earliest accounts of the story of Jesus, and they are based on the eyewitness testimony of the apostles.

The word “gospel” (Old English: “god-spel” = “good tidings”) comes from a Greek word (*euangelion* / *ευαγγελιον*) that means “good news.”

In the Greek and Roman world of the 1st century, when the Roman Empire ruled the larger Mediterranean world, the word *euangelion* had a clear set of associations that are well illustrated by a monumental inscription found in the Turkish town of Priene. It records an edict from Paulus Fabius Maximus, the Roman proconsul of Asia, issued in 9 B.C.E. The edict aligns the regional calendar with the Roman calendar, honoring Caesar Augustus by making his birthday the beginning day of the calendar year.



Wikipedia Commons [Adrian Farwell](#)

“Providence has ordered all things and set them in order by giving us Caesar Augustus, whom she has filled with virtue that he might benefit all humanity, and has sent him as a savior for us and our descendants, that he might end war and bring order to all things ... The birthday of the god was the beginning of the good news for the world ...”

Priene Inscription, text and translation from Victor Ehrenberg and A.H.M. Jones, *Documents Illustrating the Reigns of Augustus and Tiberius* (1955). Oxford. 82.

Notice that Augustus’ birth is hailed as “good news” (Grk. *euangelion*), that is, the arrival of a new ruler and a new regime of “salvation” (Grk. *soteria*) that has brought peace, order, and “benefit” (Grk. *euergesia*, literally “doing of goodness”) to the known world.

This is precisely the same vocabulary used by the earliest disciples of Jesus to describe the importance of Jesus of Nazareth and the story of his life and message, his execution at the hands of the Jewish and Roman authorities, and his resurrection from the dead into a role of cosmic authority.

Mark 1:14-15 NIV

¹⁴ ... Jesus went into Galilee, proclaiming **the good news** of God. ¹⁵ “The time has come,” he said. “The **kingdom of God has come near**. Repent and believe **the good news!**”

Romans 1:2-4 Instructor's Translation

² **The good news** ... ³ regarding **the Son of God**, who descended from David in his physical lineage, ⁴ and who was **appointed by the Holy Spirit to be the Son of God in power through his resurrection from the dead: Jesus, the Messiah, our Lord**.

Matthew 1:20-21 NASB

²⁰ ... behold, an angel of the Lord appeared to [Joseph] in a dream, saying,
“Joseph, **son of David**, do not be afraid to take Mary as your wife;
for **the child who has been conceived in her is of the Holy Spirit**.
²¹ She will bear a son; and you shall call His name Jesus,
for **he will save his people** from their sins.”

In the New Testament, the good news about Jesus focuses on his role as the divine son of Israel’s royal line (of David), whose birth and death and resurrection all lead to his rise to cosmic authority.

The word *euangelion* is the most concise, one-word summary of this message and story. It appears 12 times in the Gospel narratives and 87 times in Paul’s letters (the noun 66x and the verb 21x)! Romans 1:2-4 and 1 Corinthians 15:1-3 offer Paul’s clearest definitions.

Both Jesus and Paul derived this important word from the prophetic poetry of Isaiah (Isa. 52:7-10), where the future arrival of God’s Kingdom through the messiah is called good news (Heb. *bisser*/Grk. *euangelion*).

Isaiah 52:7-8 LEB

⁷ How delightful on the mountains are the feet of him who brings good news,
who announces peace, who **brings good news**,

who announces salvation,
who says to Zion, **"Your God reigns as a king."**

⁸ The voices of your watchmen!
They lift up their voices;
together they sing for joy;
for they clearly see Yahweh's return to Zion.

Isaiah 40:9 LEB

Get yourself up to a high mountain,
Zion, **bringer of good news!**
Lift up your voice with strength,
Jerusalem, **bringer of good news!**
Lift it up; you must not fear!
Say to the cities of Judah, **"Here is your God!"**

Psalms 96:1-2, 9-10 NASB

¹ Sing to Yahweh a new song;
sing to Yahweh, all the earth.
² Sing to Yahweh, bless his name.
Proclaim the good news of his salvation from day to day.
⁹ Worship Yahweh in holy attire;
tremble before him, all the earth.
¹⁰ Say among the nations, **"Yahweh is king!"**

This network of passages from the Hebrew Bible attaches the phrase "good news" to a royal announcement of Yahweh's rescue of his covenant people. After Israel's long history of covenant violation, God will come to rescue his people, renew the covenant, and send a faithful leader to guide his people so that they can finally be what God has called them to be: a nation of royal-priestly representatives to the nations.

Matthew's Portrait of the Good News

The Gospel of Matthew comes to us from the later 1st century C.E., and it offers a unique portrait of the good news story about Jesus of Nazareth. The arc of this story and its main themes would have been recognizable to 1st century inhabitants of the Roman Empire but also surprising and even shocking.

Matthew describes the birth of a divine King, presented as the Son of the one true God, destined to reign over the world.

Matthew 1:1 Instructor's Translation

The scroll of **the birth-beginning of Jesus Messiah,**
son of David, son of Abraham ...

Matthew 3:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ And, after being immersed,
Jesus immediately came up from the water,
and look, the skies were opened for him,
and he saw **the Spirit of God** descending like a dove,
and coming upon him,
¹⁷ and look, **a voice from the skies was speaking,**
“This is my son, the beloved one,
in him I have delight.”

Matthew 28:18-20 Instructor's Translation

¹⁸ And approaching, Jesus said to [his disciples],
“All authority in the sky and on the land has been given to me,
¹⁹ so then, when y’all go, **make disciples of all the nations,**
immersing them in the name of **the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit,**
²⁰ teaching them to keep everything that I have commanded y’all;
and look, I am with y’all all of the days,
until the conclusion of the age.”

This king was known for his mercy, and he provided food for the poor and healing for the sick and destitute.

Matthew 4:23-25 LEB

²³ And he went around through all of Galilee, **teaching in their synagogues and proclaiming the good news of the kingdom and healing every disease and every sickness among the people.**
²⁴ And a report about him went out throughout Syria, and they brought to him all those who were sick with various diseases and afflicted by torments, demon-possessed and epileptics and paralytics, and he healed them. ²⁵ And large crowds followed him from Galilee, Decapolis, Jerusalem, Judea, and from the other side of the Jordan.

But, in a shocking twist, this story focuses on growing hostility toward Jesus from the authorities of Jerusalem and the Roman Empire, resulting in a guilty verdict that led to the most shameful execution possible.

Matthew 27:37-39 Instructor's Translation

³⁷ And they put above his head the charge against him in writing:
“This is Jesus, the king of the Judeans.”
³⁸ Then two robbers were crucified with him, one on his right and one on his left.
³⁹ And those who passed by shamed him ...

Matthew’s account highlights many times over that this shameful death was actually a self-sacrifice made by Jesus as an act of service and love for others.

Matthew 20:25-28 Instructor's Translation

²⁵ But Jesus, summoning, said to them,
“Y’all know that the rulers of the nations dominate them,

and the great ones flaunt authority over them.

²⁶ It should not be this way with y'all,
but whoever desires to be a great one among y'all,
he must be the servant of y'all ...

²⁸ Just as **the son of the human did not come to be served,
but in order to serve,
and to give his life-being as a ransom on behalf of many.**

This is the surprising, shocking, and subversive story of good news that Matthew has to offer. It's not simply locked in the past, as the risen Jesus makes clear in the last sentence of the story. The good news is ongoing, as the risen Jesus is "with us" until the completion of the world story.

Reflection Question

What reflections come to mind for you considering the cultural and religious environment that gave rise to the gospels?